

What Happens When You Feel Evaluated

Why you can know what to do and still lose access to it.

THE IDEA

When a client's face changes, your attention moves off the client and onto yourself: "How do I sound? Was that wrong? Am I losing them?" You're now doing therapy and grading your performance at the same time. Your mental workspace fills up, and the skill you genuinely know becomes harder to retrieve. That's why the right answer arrives two hours later, because the pressure is gone.

WHAT IT DOES TO YOUR THINKING

When you're grounded and a client goes quiet, you can hold several possibilities: maybe they're thinking, disagreeing, ashamed, or unsure how to answer. When you're activated, that collapses to one: "I did something wrong." Then you act on it. You fill the silence or explain yourself, before either of you learns anything.

THE METHOD: NOTICE, NAME, RETURN

NOTICE Catch the first signal: tight chest, urge to speak, sudden blankness.

NAME Say it to yourself plainly: "I feel evaluated." "I want to rescue."

RETURN Come back to your body, your role, the client, and what you actually know.

THE GOAL ISN'T TO BE CALM

You'll still feel nervous, and that's allowed. You just want enough space that the feeling isn't the only thing deciding what you say next. Not perfect calm. Just a little more choice.